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FIGHTING: HAND TO HAND

Not all fights are resolved at the verbal level. On at least 34 occasions during 1963–9 peace making failed and people came to blows. There were probably other cases I did not hear about. Based on accounts of 17 incidents actually witnessed by the research group, !Kung fights tend to have the following characteristics. They are of short duration; the actual time during which blows are exchanged varies between 30 seconds and 5 minutes. Assaults are sudden and in earnest; once begun, there are no ritualized phrases or slanging matches interspersed with the fighting. An exception to this rule is the play fighting occasionally observed among young males aged 18 to 35. Here there can be lengthy sequences of posturing and sparring interspersed with bouts of wrestling. Of five such cases observed during fieldwork, two turned serious, three did not. Four of the five cases involved only males; one involved a husband and wife. There are no instances of play fights among women.

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In the case of serious fights, the atmosphere among the bystanders tends to be hysterical, although the combatants themselves often fight in dead silence, grim-faced and tight-lipped. Wrestling and punching at close quarters rather than fisticuffs seems to be the major technique for both sexes. The object of the fighter is to get a headlock on his opponent and force him to the ground. We saw no evidence of kicking or intent to harm the genitals. After the first exchange of blows, attempts are made by third parties to restrain the combatants. The fighters are forcibly separated and held back facing each other. After the fighting ceases, there is an eruption of talking and shouting by everyone — again except for the combatants, who remain silent. The discussion of the fight may continue for several hours after the event, and punching may flare again. On the other hand, we have seen people burst into

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laughter only a few minutes after a fight. After the tension is broken, partisans of the opposing sides📄377

Table 13.1 *Number of initiators and victims of fights, by sex*

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Attacker	Victim		
	Male	Female	Total
Male	11	14 ^a	25
Female	1 ^b	8	9
Total	12	22	34

may be seen joking with one another whereas only minutes before they were grappling. We did not see formal attempts at reconciliation – such as handshaking – following a fight. However, the trance dance that sometimes follows a fight may serve as a peace-making mechanism where trance performers give ritual healing to persons on both sides of the argument.

^aIn 10 of these 14 cases, a husband attacked his wife.

^bA wife attacked her husband.

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